ecosystem who work full time with EF, and they mentor all the other founders on the programme.

We also pay a stipend of 2,000 dollars per month to all fifty people. After three months, we decide to make an equity-related investment in a startup. We invest 55,000 dollars for ten per cent of the equity. And after investment, those companies go through another three months of launch programme, which is like an accelerator.

There again, they will have an Entrepreneur in Residence (EIR) and interact with external advisors who are well-known people from the industry. Then we guide them to do early traction and get early customers.

And then our final big piece comes in when they are ready for seed investments. EF exposes them to many investors in the ecosystem. We prepare them in terms of how to think about seed investing, basic material on investing, pitches, and long-term strategy.

Q. What is the duration of every cohort?

A. Our programme is typically for about six months—the first three months for company building and the next three months for acceleration.

In India, we provide support for longer periods. So, we go for at least another two to three months and then comes the investor day. After that, the funding from the first conversation with a VC takes its own time to close.

Q. What if VCs are interested in an idea but want to wait for another six months before investing?

A. When we become an investor in the company, our interests are aligned in terms of getting the startup seed funded. Formally, there is no programme support available after the end of six or eight months. But like any investor, we stay in touch and continue to introduce them to VCs and give them feedback on their product or plan of action.

Q. What all is covered in deep tech? What do cohorts work on?

A. Artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML) are the main kinds of tech we cover. More than half of our companies have some aspects of AI and ML applied to different industries. We have a vision in the robotics and nanotech fields.

We have seen aerospace tech as well. Some med-tech and biotech firms have also evolved. So, a lot of those kinds of deeply technical businesses are emerging out of EF.

Q. How do you reach out to possible individuals?

A. We have different channels. About 25 per cent of our applications are organic. People have heard about us, and they are applying to us on their own.

We are always on the lookout for smart people and those who could do well as entrepreneurs. Then we directly reach out to them. END

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Q. Which kind of technology is expected to see a boom and which are the ones that are diminishing? Which technology do you suggest students should bet on?

A. We believe in 'Inch wide and mile deep,' which means exploring all the possible technologies but, at the same time, understanding the core at a deeper level to become a thought leader in the subject. I think that there's a lot of scope in the digital transformation sector and the adoption of cloud technologies. Also, the technologies that involve data analytics study to make better and informed decisions, and will help in making the consumer future-ready, are expected to survive in the future. All types of emerging technologies like blockchain, AI/ML, IoT, etc, can be bet on.

Q. What happens to the content and white papers that are shared with you? Do you release them, publish them on the website, or open source them?

A. Yes, we share the winning ideas on our website and retain all entries on our internal website. The engineers that are responsible to mentor the students gather all the idea in one place. Then we publish these ideas on our internal website under the category 'Cloud 20-20.' This enables all the engineers in our company to read these ideas, comment on them, and later try evolving a combination of ideas to develop existing technologies. Second, we try to file patents wherever possible.

Q. Does this programme exist in other countries as well, or is it just an India driven initiative?

A. Originally, it is an India driven initiative, but we are looking forward to ways in which we can run this programme in other countries as well. So, in the future, you might see it as a global programme. END

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